Q+A

Q. How does a busy politician find the time to write a large book like this?
Because I don't sleep enough, I'm afraid! As I've often explained to people—and G.B. Shaw put it better than I can—I write for the same reason a cow gives milk; it's inside me and it's got to come out. *A Wonderland of Words: Around the Word in 101 Essays* is based on a column I wrote for *Khaleej Times* for two years.

Q. Is the English language in decline?
It's evolving. I'm not a fan of those who set themselves up as judges of other people's use of language. What's delightful about English is that it's very receptive to new influences and inputs, including words from other languages.

Q. Do you have a favourite word?
Whenever I'm asked this, especially by schoolkids, I just say my favourite word is a four-letter one—read. One word though that I started using in college and that somehow still hasn't caught on is 'defenestrate', which means 'to throw out of the window'. Every day one comes across situations where you want to defenestrate someone or something.

Q. Any other books you're working on?
I'm starting a book on the life and legacy of a guru in Kerala who deserves to be better known—Sree Narayana Guru. He was a social reformer of the late 19th-early 20th century. I want to write a short and accessible biography which draws some lessons from his legacy.

—with Amit Dixit



HAVING THE LAST WORD

Writer, politician and wordsmith **Shashi Tharoor** is out with a book of essays celebrating the magical world of words

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